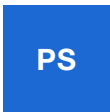


Six people looking for **one right car**

Buyer personas for the approved-used matcher: who they are, what they say they want, what actually decides it, and what happened when each of them used the tool. Research-informed working personas, built July 2026, tested against live retailer stock the same day.



Daniel, 47
The Motorway Manager



Priya, 38
The Family Consolidator



Martin, 56
The Reward Buyer



Chloe, 29
The Statement Buyer



Sam & Jordan, 34
The Fun-Sized Family



Meg, 58
The Electric Downsizer

THE CONTEXT

What the research says about used-car buyers

14 hrs

of online research before a buyer contacts anyone, peaking 7–9pm

Wonderful.co.uk, UK used market trends 2025

47%

of UK buyers travelled 25 miles or less to buy; the tool's "worth the drive" tier lives here

UK buyer journey research, 2025

60%

of under-35s' research happens on a phone; over-45s still skew desktop

Motortech.ai, The UK Car Buyer in 2025

88%

call colour a key purchase factor, even though most end up in white, black, grey or silver

Axalta global colour survey

The journey is online-first; the purchase stays local. People do the work in the evenings on their own sofa, then buy from a dealer they can reach. A tool anchored to one retailer, honest about what sits just beyond it, matches how buyers actually behave.

Affordability is the mood. Large shares of buyers say they would switch brands over price, and most budget in monthly payments rather than totals. **Taste decides late:** people narrow to a shortlist on facts, then choose between near-identical cars on colour and character, exactly where the tool's refine step sits.

The brands attract different people. BMW's approved-used buyer is established, 35–55, and buys certainty: warranty, history, no surprises. MINI's skews younger, urban and image-led; the car is a statement first and transport second, and the Countryman exists so young families don't have to trade the statement away.

Evidence honesty: these personas are synthesised from published market research, the brands' own positioning, and this project's stock analysis. They are not interview-based. Treat them as strong, testable hypotheses about real customers, not as ground truth. Sources are cited in full in the companion document, docs/personas.md.

"I've had company cars for ten years. This one's my own money, so it needs to be right."

LIFE

Regional operations director, outside Perth. Married, two teenagers.

MILES

~22,000 a year, mostly A9/M90

BUDGET

£22–38k

SHOPPING FOR

Diesel or plug-in hybrid saloon/estate

DEVICE

Desktop, evenings, spreadsheet in the next tab

SAYS HE WANTS

A comfortable, frugal motorway car. Diesel by habit; hybrid-curious but no home charger yet.

ACTUALLY DECIDES ON

Total cost of ownership and the absence of doubt. First private purchase in a decade, which makes him the classic Approved Used customer: he is buying the warranty and the history as much as the car.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A 520d-shaped answer with the economy argued in his terms: what this car costs to run at his mileage.

WHAT HE ASKS THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- Monthly finance cost, not just sticker price
- Warranty length and service history up front

TESTED · CLEAR WINNER

The tool named a 520d M Sport Touring at 91%, reasoned about his big annual mileage in plain words, and showed the plug-in alternative beside it. Served.

"If the buggy and the dog don't both fit, it doesn't matter how clever it is."

LIFE

GP in Perthshire. Two children under 8, one spaniel. Going from two cars to one.

MILES

~9,000 a year + Glasgow grandparent runs

BUDGET

£25–45k · wallbox already on the drive

SHOPPING FOR

Electric or plug-in SUV/estate

DEVICE

Mobile in stolen moments; decides on desktop with partner

SAYS SHE WANTS

An electric family car big enough for everything, safe, and honest about range.

ACTUALLY DECIDES ON

Whether she believes the boot claim (she thinks in buggies and dogs, not litres), ISOFIX in the back, and what the range really is on a cold motorway run.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

An iX1/X1-hybrid-shaped shortlist with practicality reasons front and centre, shareable with her partner.

WHAT SHE ASKS THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- Safety ratings and ISOFIX
- Winter range, said honestly
- Monthly cost on PCP

TESTED · SEVEN-WAY TIE

Seven electric SUVs fit her equally; the page says so and lets her narrow by taste. Friction found: near-identical cars shown as separate cards, and a slightly stronger match 23 miles away goes unmentioned. Both are on the improvement list.

"I've spent thirty years being sensible. Not this time."

LIFE

Sold his share of an engineering firm. Kids gone. Promised himself this for twenty years.

MILES

~6,000 a year, sunny ones

BUDGET

£30–60k

SHOPPING FOR

Petrol convertible, quick enough to feel it

DEVICE

Desktop; will phone the dealer rather than fill in a form

SAYS HE WANTS

A petrol convertible. He is decisive about the shape and open-minded about almost everything else.

ACTUALLY DECIDES ON

How it makes him feel: the sound, the colour on his drive, the test drive. Happily travels 50 miles for the right car, which makes him the "worth the drive" tier's ideal customer.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

The tool being straight with him: his local dealer has no convertibles, and the right car is a short drive away.

WHAT HE ASKS THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- A way to act: no phone number, enquiry or test-drive booking on the results page

TESTED · NOT HERE, BUT NEARBY

"No convertibles at Grassicks right now. The nearest is 18.1 miles away." Local coupés shown honestly as the closest here, a 94% Z4 leading the nearby list. Exactly the honesty this page was rebuilt for. Served.



Chloe Bennett, 29

The Statement Buyer

MINI

“It's the first car I've bought with my own money. It's not allowed to be boring.”

LIFE

Marketing manager in Luton, in London three days a week.

MILES

Low; city and station runs

BUDGET

£14–22k · budgets monthly, not in totals

SHOPPING FOR

Petrol 3-door hatch · it's a MINI or a Fiat 500

DEVICE

Entirely mobile, 9pm, Pinterest board open

SAYS SHE WANTS

A 3-door petrol MINI hatch. Classic trim is fine.

ACTUALLY DECIDES ON

The colour and the roof. Full stop. The one that photographs best outside her flat wins.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A tie she gets to break herself: cars whose paint she can see, one tap to say "the green one". She is the whole reason the refine step exists.

WHAT SHE ASKS THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- Monthly payment and insurance group

TESTED · SIX-WAY TIE

Six Coopers in five visible colours, swatches on every card, colour chips to narrow with. Two taps from "six-way tie" to "your perfect MINI". Served, precisely as designed.



Sam & Jordan Reyes, 34

The Fun-Sized Family

MINI

“Having a kid doesn't mean we have to drive something grey.”

LIFE

Graphic designer and paramedic in Luton. One toddler, an allotment, street parking.

MILES

Town miles plus weekend escapes

BUDGET

£18–30k

SHOPPING FOR

Countryman or Clubman, petrol (no charger on their street)

DEVICE

Mobile, in shifts, sending each other links: “this one?”

SAY THEY WANT

A practical MINI: buggy-and-shop boot, cheap to run, still theirs to look at.

ACTUALLY DECIDE ON

Whether the buggy fits with the weekly shop, doors that open in tight car parks, and the styling still saying MINI, which the contrast roof carries.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Countryman-shaped answers with practicality reasons they believe, without being handed a grey box.

WHAT THEY ASK THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- Boot size in buggy terms, not litres
- Running costs beyond mpg: tax, insurance

TESTED · FIVE-WAY TIE + AN HONEST ASIDE

Five Countrymans fit their brief, and the page also volunteers that the plug-in hybrid they wondered about is 21.9 miles away. Two honest messages, one page, no contradiction. Served. (Also caught: 21 refine chips is too many; on the fix list.)



Meg Whitlow, 58

The Electric Downsizer



“I don't want clever. I want honest, comfortable, and a plug.”

LIFE

Recently retired teacher, St Albans. Downsizing from an X1 that's too big for her life now.

MILES

Short: town, garden centre, grandchildren

BUDGET

£15–25k · wallbox fitted last spring

SHOPPING FOR

Small electric automatic, comfortable

DEVICE

Desktop, daytime, methodical. Prints things.

SAYS SHE WANTS

A small electric car with a plug she already has. Not a badge purchase; the MINI is simply the charming version of the right size.

ACTUALLY DECIDES ON

Trust. Range said plainly, heated seats and parking sensors present, an automatic gearbox, a dealer she can reach, a warranty page she reads twice.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A MINI Electric with honest numbers and the comfort equipment visible on the card, not buried in a brochure.

WHAT SHE ASKS THAT THE TOOL CAN'T HEAR YET

- Winter range, honestly stated
- That it's automatic: true of every electric MINI, but nothing tells her so

TESTED · TWO-WAY TIE

Two identical MINI Electrics, Chili Red versus Midnight Black; the tool offers exactly that choice as two taps. Served, with one gap: the gearbox is known but never shown. On the fix list.

WHAT TESTING THROUGH THEIR EYES FOUND

Every persona was served. The gaps are around the match, not in it.

All six personas landed on honest, coherent results, including the hard cases: the tool admits ties instead of inventing a winner, says "not here, but 18 miles away" when that's the truth, and lets taste make the final call. The sharpest unmet needs are money, trust and action: what it costs monthly, why approved-used can be believed, and how to actually get the car once you've found it.

Fix now (small and sharp)

1. Cap the refine chips (21 offered over five cars)
2. Group near-identical cars: "2 available, in blue and grey"
3. Correct the runner-up wording when a tie is bigger than the page shows
4. Show the gearbox on every card
5. Say "Countryman", not "SUV", in MINI's own voice

Next (design and data)

1. Monthly-cost layer: indicative finance per car
2. Retailer handoff: phone, enquiry, test-drive booking
3. Approved-used trust strip: warranty, history, returns
4. Flag a stronger match nearby even when the local result is good
5. Investigate: insurance group, tax, winter range, safety data

Where to go deeper: the full personas with sources live in docs/personas.md; the complete test log and prioritised feature list in docs/persona-findings.md; both replayable any time with **npm run personas**.